

FASHION RESTORED

The Restoration of the English monarchy in 1660 signalled the dawn of a new age of prosperity for the English aristocracy, which was reflected in the fashions of the time. Charles II was self-indulgent and foppish, and his courtiers soon followed suit. Despite their extravagances, English nobles took an interest in charitable causes, such as the one depicted in the painting, *The Tichborne Dole*, opposite, in which the Lord of the Manor in the village of Tichborne distributes bread to the poor. This painting showcases the lavish fashions worn by the noble class, in contrast with those worn by the less fortunate.

The central male figure in the middle ground wears a long and ornate waistcoat, fastened with close-set buttons from throat to hem, underneath a plainer coat. This was one of the many fashions introduced by Charles II. The figure also wears an elaborate lace cravat and a periwig, an indispensable part of wealthy fashionable attire. Shoes are high-heeled and square-toed.

The two women to his left show female fashions of the day. Their bodices, with a horizontal décolletage, are long, pointed, and fastened in the front with jewelled clasps. They wear full-puffed sleeves to the elbows, and their skirts are gathered at the hips in tight pleats, opening down the front over an ornate petticoat. Their bodice and skirts are joined, but poorer women would wear them separately, in different colours. Skirts were raised – to the toe for court women and to the instep for peasant women. Though the women use stays, the overall effect is one of increasing freedom.

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The King hath in Council declared his resolution of setting a fashion for clothes, which he will never alter. It will be a vest, I know not well how, but it is to teach the nobility thrift, and will do good.

SAMUEL PEPYS, 8 OCTOBER 1666

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◁ **THE TICHBORNE DOLE** This scene, painted by Gillis van Tilborgh in 1671, depicts an English festival of charity during the Feast of the Annunciation.

